colonial times, tribal people have been protected by a debt relief regulation. The regulation, applicable to what were popularly called ‘agency areas’ in the erstwhile Madras Presidency—hill tracts inhabited by tribal households and designated as scheduled areas—was, by far, one of the most sympathetic laws that I had come across. It provided that any and all debt owed by a tribal to a non-tribal stood completely annulled. It was summary justice at its simplest. All it required for an indebted tribal person to free himself of debt was to come forward and report that he owed a non-tribal a certain amount of money, and I, as the subcollector, could then issue an order that all that debt was cancelled. What was more, if the non-tribal still pressed for repayment, he could be jailed. By way of affirmative action, the debt relief regulation was remarkable for its extraordinary clarity of purpose and simplicity of process.

The regulation was also most ineffective. My first instinct was to believe that all tribal debt would have been written off since the regulation had been in force since colonial times. But during my visits to villages, I realized that nothing had changed. The moneylenders were still there, tribal households were still borrowing from them, and generations of them were still going into bondage. I thought maybe my predecessors didn’t pay attention to this task, and I would make amends for past negligence.

In all my youthful enthusiasm, I went around tribal hamlets and encouraged tribal households to report their debt so that I could then write it off and free them from debt and bondage. I simply didn’t make a dent. Not one would come forward. It took me several months to understand why. Their total silence had to do with the dependence of the tribals on the non-tribals. Imagine a tribal actually coming forward and getting his debt written off by the subcollector. From that very moment, not only he, but his entire village, would be ostracized by the moneylender community. The net result of my misguided heroism would have been to cut off tribal households from their only source of loans.

Consider these scenarios. Where would the tribals go for an emergency loan if they had a sick child who had to be taken to a doctor in the nearest town in the middle of the night? Where would they go if their animals died